# STATE SCAN

**UTTAR PRADESH: LAST MILE PUSH BY AKHILESH** *PG 28*

**GOA: THE HARDEST NUT TO CRACK** *PG 30*



PTI

**AGENTS OF CHANGE** Voters at the BTC polls in Sonitpur district, Assam, Sept. 22; below, CM Himanta Biswa Sarma



▶ ASSAM

# BOLT FROM BODOLAND FOR SARMA

**The BJP faces its first big rebuff in a decade in Assam, as Bodoland falls back on old favourite BPF. Will there be a larger impact on the 2026 election?**

*By* **Kaushik Deka**

**SINCE INITIATING THE BJP'S NORTHEASTERN EXPANSION NEARLY A DECADE AGO**, Himanta Biswa Sarma has been the lord of all political tides in his precincts. That spell of dominance stands interrupted. On September 22, the Assam chief minister faced his first significant electoral rebuke at home. Or call it near-home, for the arena was the autonomous Bodoland Territorial Council (BTC), not his primary turf.

The Bodoland People's Front (BPF) swept 28 out of 40 seats, many with huge margins. The BJP, which went solo, was down to a humiliating five. The ally it had built up and now abandoned, the United People's Party Liberal (UPPL), managed only seven seats, nearly half of its 2020 tally.

The outright majority for the BPF, under its 56-year-old chief Hagrama Mohilary, restores an 'old normal'. Defections had marred the BPF story post-2020—after the BJP-UPPL duet denied it power, despite its 17 seats making it the single largest party. But its grassroots footprint had never faded. These results confirm that: they are a verdict on the BJP's attempt to seed an alternate network into the Bodo subsoil via a local proxy.

Under the 1975-born Pramod Boro, the UPPL seemed to signify an evolution beyond the BPF's personality-driven